



Via Nova this Fall

Friends, I am overjoyed to share a glimpse of what has been going on at Via Nova for the past few months. To put it simply, the past few months has been a testament to God's abundant generosity. I have seen this supernatural generosity in the hospitality and eagerness of the wider community of Lafayette to grow in faith, the wisdom of my teachers, and through the movements of the Holy Spirit in prayer. The other Fellows and I have been welcomed into many homes for meals and fellowship, we have hosted many beautiful gatherings for the larger community in our own homes, and we have had rich conversations in both seminar and community events discovering truths about God and man. I accepted a job with Dr. Damon Cudihiy and Dr. Johnny Voltz at Acadiana OB/GYN where I have had the experience of being a Catholic on mission in the workplace. Via has offered me an abundant life that has been rich and well ordered. Time for prayer, work, community, leisure, study and play are all woven into each day. The Lord has blessed us tremendously. Here are a few highlights!



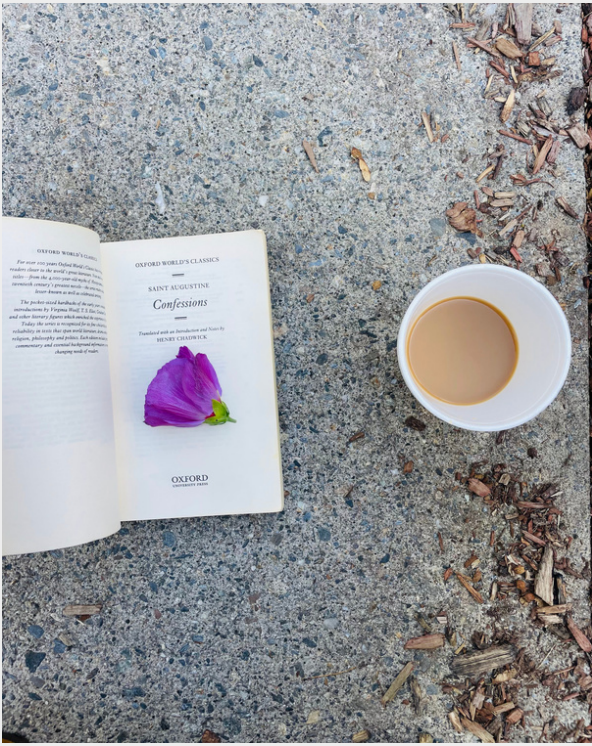
The Theodora House, where I live with the other women in Via, Rachel and Mel



All of the Fellows during a hike in Colorado

STUDY

In seminar at Via, I have been learning new things each day that bring me closer to God. We began the year's seminars with a sequence on Ancient Israel led by Fr. John Joseph Bourque CJC and Dcn. Adam Conque. Recently we moved into the Ancient Greece sequence which is led by Fr. Josh Guillory and occasionally Luke Ungarino and Mel Leece. We are currently reading Homer's *Odyssey*, featuring Odysseus' journey home from Troy. The epic poem is filled with action, anticipation, excitement and beautiful poetry. One gem from the last couple of weeks of seminar has been experiencing how good literature can provoke self-reflection. A recent reflection was provoked in books fifteen through seventeen of the *Odyssey*. In these books, Odysseus is disguised as a poor man as he arrives home to Ithaka. In these few scenes, Homer highlights a significant theme seen throughout the *Odyssey* of hospitality to the poor man. When Odysseus arrives at Ithaka disguised we see Eumaios, the swineherd, taking him into his home. Eumaios did not know who the poor man was and yet opened his home generously. Pious ancient pagans understood that if a poor man came to you, you would care for him because of the chance that he could be a god in disguise. As I was reading this scene I could not stop thinking about the poor in my own life. Do I care for the poor in front of me in a way that glorifies God? Am I as hospitable to the poor as I could be? How can I take better care of the poor in front of me? How can I be more intentional about seeing God in the person in front of me as Eumaios and many of the ancients did?



WORK

Similar to how we see a theme of treating the poor well in the *Odyssey*, my work at Acadiana OB/GYN has given me many opportunities to love the person in front of me. It has been a joy and a challenge to live this mission out at Acadiana OB/GYN. One highlight of my time working here was when I had the opportunity to shadow a live birth. Witnessing the moment a mother meets her child for the first time is an inimitable experience. The memory of that moment comes to mind often as I care for pregnant women in their preparation for delivery and motherhood. It is a treasured space and an honor to be invited into care for women as they prepare for the delivery of their child. As I face challenges at work, I am always reminded of how blessed I am to work with the poor that are women and mothers bringing new life into this world!



We have hosted many events at Via Nova over the past couple of months!

One gathering that I particularly enjoyed was the Fellows' presentations. Each fellow prepares and presents a presentation at the end of each seminar sequence to begin a conversation about something meaningful. These presentations have been a wonderful space for inviting others into the community of Via Nova. One of my favorite conversations was when we discussed humility, a topic presented by Sam LeBlanc, one of the fellows. What even is humility? Is it being made low? Throughout our conversation, we wrestled with these questions and concluded that humility is knowing oneself fully before God. This conclusion brought up the question: is humility possible without God? We have yet to find the answer to that thought, perhaps it is something you can ponder or maybe you have the answer. It has been a gift to be around a community of people who love to wrestle with the truth and be enlightened by it.

Some Events We've Hosted:

- Poetry nights
- Potlucks
- Game nights
- Celebratory meals for feast days
- Presentations by the Fellows
- “Money and the Gospel” discussion series



PRAYER

In the mornings, we visit the St. Patrick's adoration chapel for our daily personal prayer of forty-five minutes to an hour. We are blessed to have daily mass, which we regularly attend at Saint Patrick's in the morning or Our Lady of Wisdom in the evening. At the end of each day we enter into our communal prayer with the liturgy of the hours. Gratitude has been a theme in prayer throughout this fall. I recently wrote a litany of thanksgiving in response to this gratitude that I wanted to share!

A Litany of Thanksgiving

Give thanks to the Lord for He is Good

God's love is everlasting

Come let us praise God joyfully

Let us come to Him with thanksgiving

For the generosity of all of my donors and benefactors

I thank you Lord

For the opportunity to pray each day and attend mass

I thank you Lord

For the opportunity to learn more about You

I thank you Lord

For the gift of meaningful conversations

I thank you Lord

For all the unforeseen graces you give me each day

I thank you Lord

For the opportunity to receive and care for women

I thank you Lord

For all your poor and the ways you invite me to serve them

I thank you Lord

For the past four months of growth in Via Nova

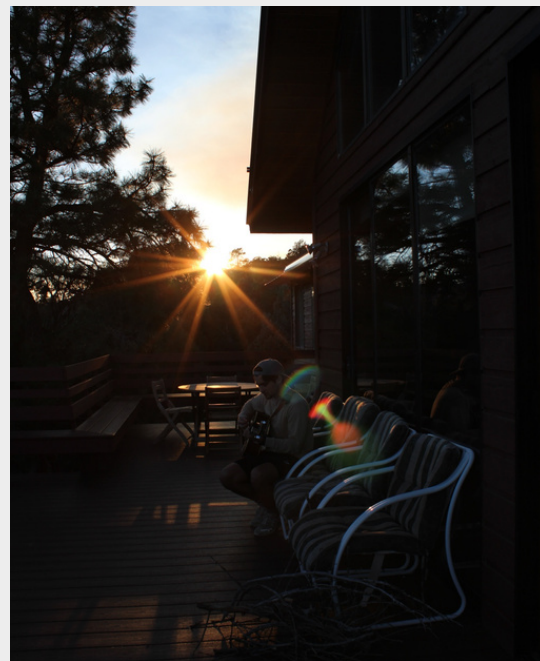
I Praise You

For all of the times that are difficult and sanctifying

I Praise You

I give thanks to the Lord

For God's Love is everlasting



I am deeply grateful to the many that have kept me in their prayers and to my abundantly generous donors. The past few months at Via have been deeply grace-filled because of you.

Know that if you are receiving this newsletter I pray for you by name daily. Let me know if you have any specific prayer intentions. May God be with you.

God Bless,
Ann-Ayrise Salvatierra

